TWO SMALL ROGUELITES

Delve & Dice and Scrapline: two concepts that reuse Cup Heroes' structure with much lighter monetization

Purpose

Two concepts that borrow a few systems from the Cup Heroes teardown (wave fights, three-card upgrades, a reward multiplier, layered meta) and sell to players on a much smaller, fairer scale. These are ideas, not specs.

Reading Key

Every claim is tagged so you can tell research from design ideas:

- **SOURCED** Taken from a cited source (see the Sources page)
- **INFERRED** My reasoning from the sources; not proven
- **PROPOSED** A design proposal for us to debate
- All art is placeholder SVG drawn for this brief



Tavern hub: one big DELVE button



Garage hub: your rig is the hero

Market research

Why a dungeon crawler and a post-apocalyptic game; small-scale benchmarks (p.2–3)

System filter

What we keep from Cup Heroes and what we cut (p.4)

Delve & Dice

Pitch, loop, meta, economy and mockups (p.5–7)

Scrapline

Pitch, loop, meta, economy and mockups (p.8–10)

Built on the user-supplied Cup Heroes Game Design Inspiration Brief.

1. MARKET RESEARCH

Why a Dungeon Crawler and a Post-Apocalyptic Game

Roguelikes are growing

- SOURCED AppMagic (2025 monetization report): roguelike titles **grew 26.2% YoY**, while RPG revenue overall fell 17% to $11bn.
- SOURCED Sensor Tower: mobile games made about **$82B** in 2025 (+1%). RPG is declining; strategy ($20.2B) and puzzle are growing.
- INFERRED The roguelite *format* is the healthy part of a shrinking RPG market.

Dungeon crawlers work at small scale

- SOURCED Soul Knight: IAPs are only **$0.99–$3.99** (mostly character unlocks). Adapty estimates about $400K/month.
- SOURCED Shattered Pixel Dungeon: **solo developer**, no ads or microtransactions, cosmetic-only supporter extras.
- SOURCED Archero 2 (the heavy end): $32.8M in its first 30 days.
- INFERRED The fantasy-crawler audience accepts both light and heavy monetization.

Post-apocalyptic is a theme, not a genre

- SOURCED Last War: Survival: **>$900M** lifetime, 60M+ downloads (Sensor Tower, via wnhub).
- SOURCED Whiteout Survival: **$500M** in about a year (Sensor Tower, via TechNode).
- SOURCED Both are 4X strategy games; Sensor Tower's regional apocalypse charts are dominated by strategy.
- INFERRED The theme draws spenders, but almost no roguelite is chasing them. That's the gap.

Why not Space? I couldn't find data on space roguelites specifically. Sensor Tower's space charts are led by unrelated games (Honkai: Star Rail, Galaxy Attack), and one 'Space Survivor' title shows about $54/week in the UK. That doesn't rule space out, I just couldn't back it up. **DnD and RPG Adventure** are folded into Concept A as its theme.

Figures are third-party estimates (AppMagic, Sensor Tower, Adapty) unless noted. Full list on the Sources page.

How Small Roguelites Make Money on Mobile

Game	Model	Reported performance	Source
Balatro (mobile)	Premium $9.99, no ads or IAP	~$4.4M in ~2 months after launch (Sep 2024); averaged ~$71K/day in Nov	AppMagic via PocketGamer.biz
Slay the Spire (mobile)	Premium $9.99 (Humble)	Android: ~10K downloads and ~$90K in a month (stale snapshot)	Sensor Tower page; TouchArcade
20 Minutes Till Dawn	Separate free and $4.99 Premium listings (Erabit port)	Premium: ~230K Android downloads; ~9.3K in the last 30 days	AppBrain; Google Play
Brotato (mobile)	Premium listings (Android one published by Erabit)	iOS ~$10K/mo; Android ~$20K/mo	apprank.io; TrendApps (estimates)
Soul Knight	F2P, small IAPs $0.99–$3.99	~$400K/mo; ~300K downloads/mo	Adapty paywall library (estimate)
Shattered Pixel Dungeon	Free / pay-what-you-want, cosmetic supporter extras	Steam alone: ~54.9K copies, ~$467K gross	Raijin (estimate); Flathub; itch.io
Archero 2 (reference)	Heavy F2P: gems, packs, passes	$6.6M first week, $32.8M first 30 days	AppMagic via PocketGamer.biz

Pattern 1: Premium

A one-time price of $4.99–$9.99. Balatro shows the ceiling for a hit; Brotato's mobile listings show what more typical premium sales look like.

Pattern 2: Free + Premium

Two separate listings, as with 20 Minutes Till Dawn on Google Play. Erabit Studios has ported both 20MTD and Brotato, so a publisher for this route exists.

Pattern 3: Light F2P

Unlocks you can earn or buy at a few dollars each, like Soul Knight. No gacha or premium currency is needed.

All revenue numbers are third-party estimates with different methods and time windows. Don't compare them directly; use them only as a sense of scale.

3. SYSTEM FILTER

What We Keep From Cup Heroes, and What We Cut

KEEP (the fun parts)

These systems keep the play loop engaging and don't depend on heavy spending:

- Short wave fights on one readable screen
- Three-card upgrade picks between fights, with a small paid reroll
- Run currency kept separate from meta currency
- A tactile reward multiplier mini-game (re-themed for each concept)
- Hero/class roster with a short trait path and visible locked nodes
- Daily calendar and a daily seeded challenge
- Big single primary button, progress always on screen, small celebrations

CUT OR SHRINK (the heavy parts)

These drive Cup Heroes' high spending and are what you wanted to avoid:

- ~~Premium gem currency~~: we price everything in real dollars, so there's no exchange-rate confusion
- ~~Booster/shard packs~~: no random paid rewards
- ~~Countdown bundles with value tags~~: no artificial urgency
- ~~Stacked pass + gems + boosters~~: at most one optional pass, cosmetic only
- ~~Forced interstitial ads~~: rewarded ads only, always opt-in
- ~~Guilds and other social systems~~: out of scope for a small team
- No energy or stamina system: play as much as you like

PROPOSED Target: **about 4–6 store items in total** and **at most 3 currencies** (run currency, meta currency and an optional season currency). Cup Heroes shows at least 4 currencies and 6+ offer types on its menus.

Cup Heroes observations come from the supplied teardown (pages 2, 7 and 8).

CONCEPT A · DUNGEON CRAWLER / D&D

Delve & Dice

Pick a party of three adventurers and clear a cursed dungeon room by room. Every big moment comes down to a dice roll you can see.

Fantasy

A tabletop session in your pocket: a tavern hub, classes, dungeon floors, and dice you can feel.

Run length

10–15 minutes: 5 floors of about 8 rooms, with a boss every 5th floor.

Hook vs. Cup Heroes

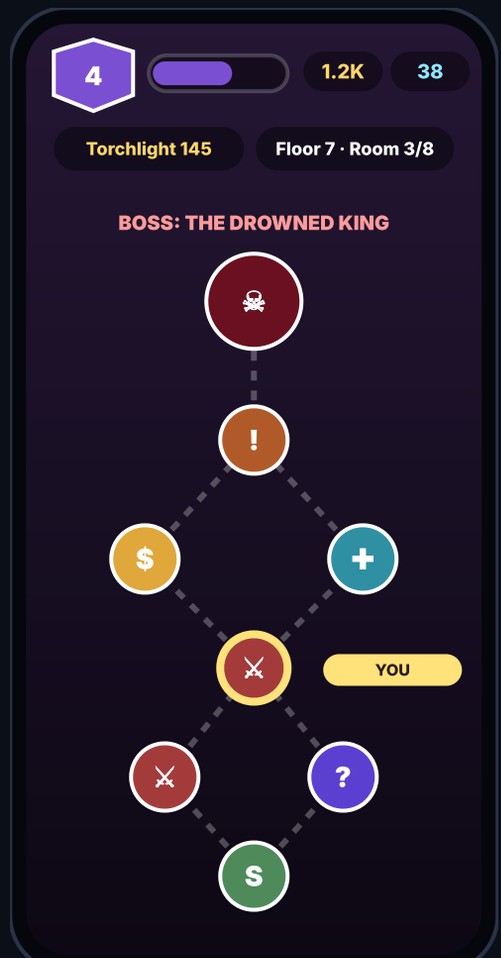
Upgrades and rewards hinge on visible d20 rolls (a natural 20 triggers boons). The randomness is the theme, not a paywall.

Audience

Players who like Soul Knight, Slay the Spire or Archero, plus tabletop fans.



Tavern hub: one big DELVE button



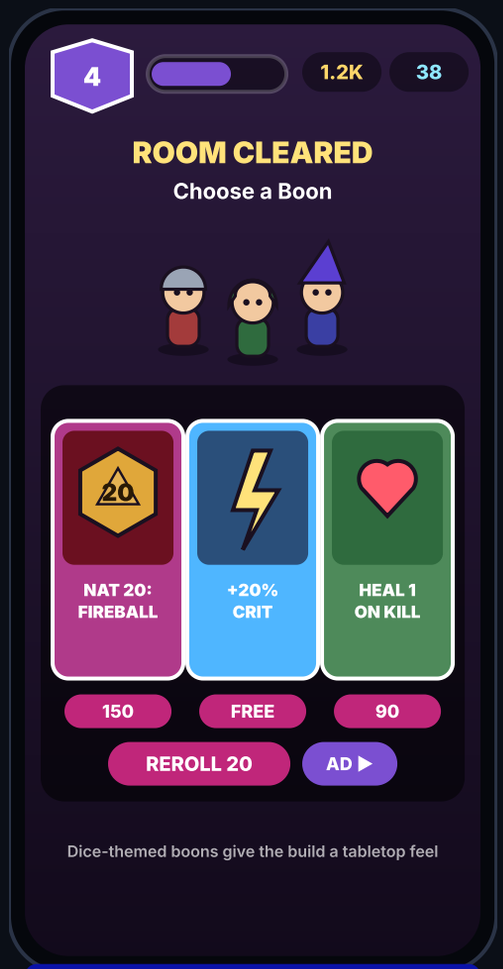
Room map: branch every 1–2 rooms

All art is placeholder SVG mockups. Party size, floor counts and run times are starting proposals.

CONCEPT A · CORE LOOP

Run Structure & Boon Choices

PARTY UP — Pick 3 classes
› **DELVE** — Choose a room path
› **FIGHT** — Auto-battle waves
› **BOON** — Pick 1 of 3
› **LOOT ROLL** — Dice multiply the chest
› **TAVERN** — Spend Gold
› **RETURN** — Daily delve



Boon pick: three cards, optional reroll



Loot Roll: dice multiply the boss chest

Room types

Combat · Elite · Trap (a d20 save) · Shrine (trade HP for a boon) · Merchant · Rest · Boss. A branching path every 1–2 rooms means a choice every minute.

Boons

Some boons are dice-keyed ("Natural 20: Fireball", "Roll 15+: dodge"), others are flat stats. Most class builds lean on one dice mechanic. Reroll costs Torchlight, or one optional ad.

Loot Roll

Replaces Cup Heroes' pachinko board. After a boss, roll 3–5 dice into a tray; the faces multiply Gold. A rare natural 20 drops a class shard. One extra roll per day from an optional ad.

Inspiration: Cup Heroes three-card shop and multiplier mini-game (pages 5–6), re-themed around dice.

Classes, Currencies & a Fair Shop

Run currency: Torchlight

Earned in rooms; spent at merchants and on rerolls. Resets after each run.

Meta currency: Gold

Comes from Loot Rolls. Spent on class levels, the tavern and unlocking classes.

Classes

8 at launch (Fighter, Rogue, Cleric, Wizard, Ranger, Bard, Paladin, Warlock), each with a 6-node trait path.

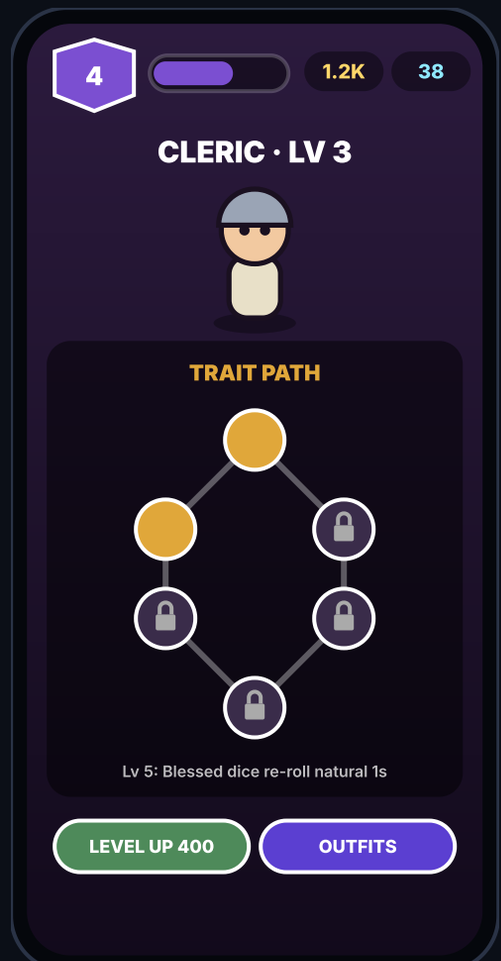
Retention

7-day calendar, a daily seeded dungeon with a leaderboard, and weekly 'module' modifiers.

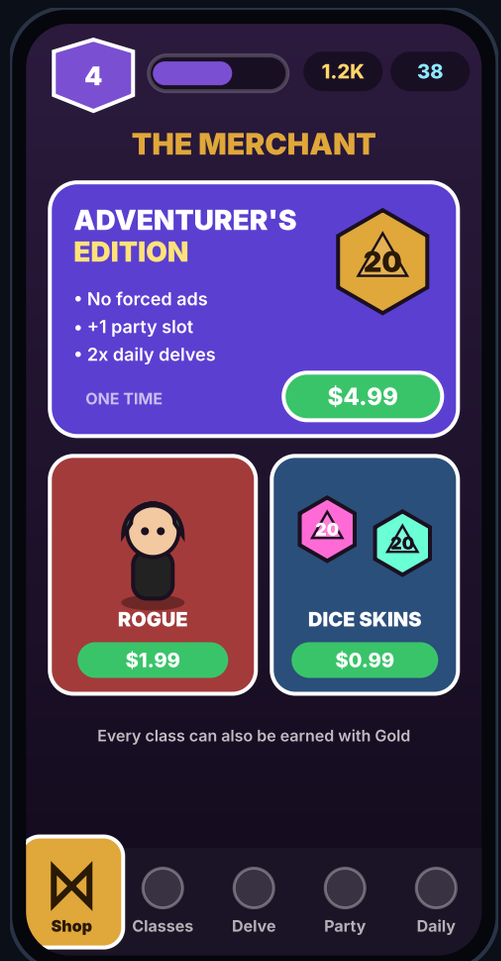
Store (4 items, priced in dollars)

- **$4.99 Adventurer's Edition**, one-time: no forced ads, +1 party slot, 2x daily delves
- **$1.99 class unlocks**: every class can also be earned with Gold
- **$0.99–$1.99 dice skins and outfits**: cosmetic only
- **Rewarded ads**: optional reroll or extra Loot Roll, capped per day

INFERRED Alternative: sell it as a **$4.99–$6.99 premium game** with no IAP, like Slay the Spire or Balatro, keeping only the cosmetics. The design doesn't change.



Class screen: short trait path, locks visible



Shop: about 4 SKUs, no gems, no timers

Prices are proposals benchmarked against Soul Knight ($0.99–$3.99 IAP) and premium roguelites ($4.99–$9.99).

CONCEPT B · POST-APOCALYPTIC

Scrapline

You drive an armored rig across a ruined wasteland. Choose your route, survive raids at every stop, and bolt salvaged weapons onto the truck until it's a monster.

Fantasy

Road-warrior convoy and scavenger survival: the truck is your hero and your build.

Run length

10–15 minutes: a route of about 10 stops ending in a warlord convoy boss.

Hook vs. Cup Heroes

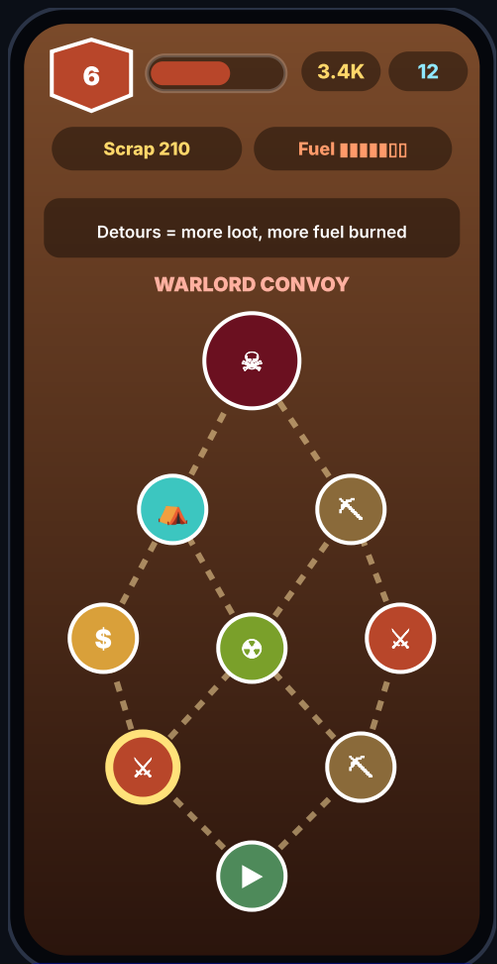
Upgrades physically appear on the truck, so you can see your build. Fuel makes every route choice a risk.

Audience

Fans of post-apocalyptic strategy games (Last War, Whiteout Survival) who want something shorter and fairer, plus survivor-like players.



Garage hub: your rig is the hero



Route map: fuel turns every route into a choice

All art is placeholder SVG mockups. Stop counts and run times are starting proposals.

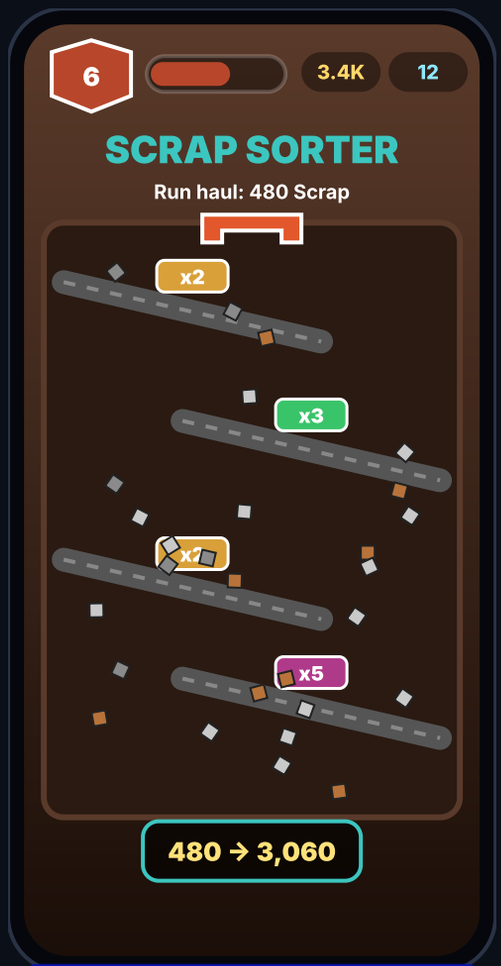
CONCEPT B · CORE LOOP

Route, Raid & Salvage

ROLL OUT Pick rig + crew › **ROUTE** Choose the next stop › **RAID** Defend the truck › **SALVAGE** Pick 1 of 3 parts › **SORT** Scrap Sorter multiplier › **SETTLE** Build Haven › **RETURN** Supply runs



Raid + part pick: upgrades bolt onto the truck



Scrap Sorter: multiplies the run haul

Stops

Raid · Scavenge (pick 1 of 2 crates) · Trader · Radstorm (a hazard modifier) · Outpost (repair) · Boss convoy. Each stop costs fuel, and longer routes pay better.

Raids

Wave fights where raiders come from both sides and the truck holds the middle. The parts you've bolted on fire automatically, like Cup Heroes' auto-combat but with the truck at the center.

Scrap Sorter

Replaces Cup Heroes' pachinko board. Your haul tumbles down conveyor belts through magnet gates that multiply it (x2, x3, x5). The physics are the same as Cup Heroes' board, but it's themed as a junkyard.

Inspiration: Cup Heroes wave combat, upgrade shop and multiplier board (pages 5–6), re-themed.

CONCEPT B · META & ECONOMY

Haven, Currencies & a Fair Shop

Run currency: Scrap

Earned at stops and spent at traders during the run. What's left at the end goes through the Scrap Sorter.

Meta currency: Parts

What comes out of the Sorter. Spent on Haven buildings, chassis and crew.

Haven (settlement)

6 buildings that give permanent bonuses and unlock new chassis (Buggy, Truck, Bus, Tanker). It's the base-building of 4X without the PvP.

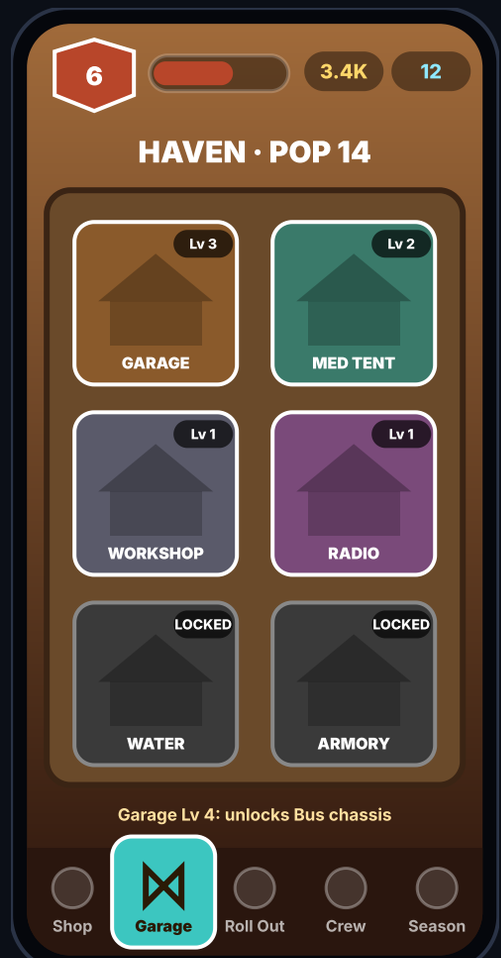
Retention

Daily Supply Run bounties, a 7-day calendar, and a 28-day Road Season with a free track.

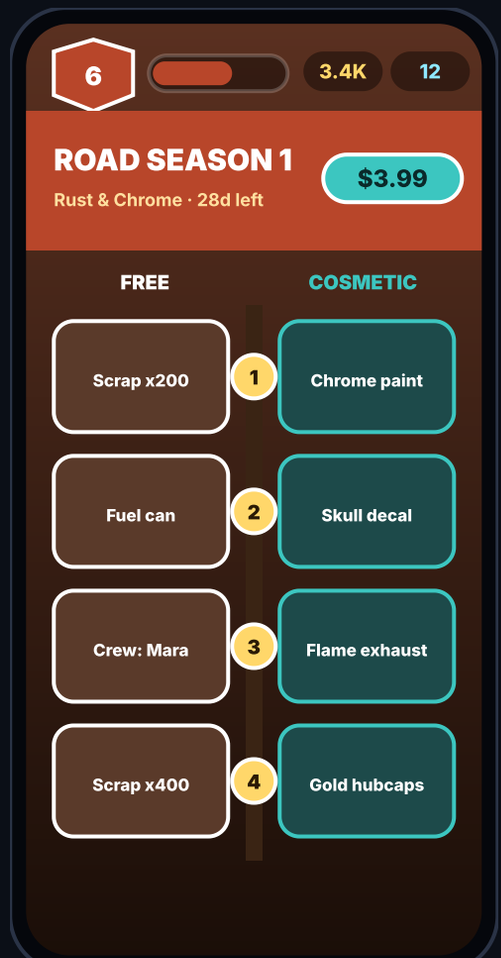
Store (4 items, priced in dollars)

- **$2.99 No Forced Ads**, one-time; optional ads still give bonuses
- **$1.99 Starter Rig**, one-time: a unique chassis plus Parts
- **$3.99 Road Season**: the premium track is *cosmetic only* (paint, decals, exhaust)
- **Rewarded ads**: one revive per run, or double the Sorter haul

INFERRED Cup Heroes' heavy pressure comes from stacking a pass, gems, boosters and timed bundles. Here the pass is the only recurring purchase, and it never sells power.



Settlement: base-building meta without PvP



Road Season: premium track is cosmetic only

Ad mix: Sensor Tower separates ads-first titles (~80% of revenue from ads) from IAP-first ones (~78–80% IAP). Scrapline leans IAP with optional ads.

4. SIDE BY SIDE

Comparing the Two Concepts

	Delve & Dice	Scrapline
Genre / theme	Dungeon crawler · D&D fantasy	Route roguelite · post-apocalyptic
Systems borrowed	Three-card picks, multiplier (Loot Roll), class roster, daily calendar	Wave fights, three-card picks, multiplier (Scrap Sorter), base meta, season pass
Revenue model	One-time unlock + small class/cosmetic items, or premium	Light F2P: no-ads purchase + starter pack + cosmetic pass
Store items	4	4
Evidence it can work	SOURCED Soul Knight, Shattered Pixel Dungeon, Balatro, Slay the Spire	SOURCED The theme earns huge sums in 4X; INFERRED that it transfers to roguelites is unproven
Art scope	Chibi fantasy party and dungeon tiles; lots of cheap asset packs exist	One truck plus modular parts and a few raider types; arguably cheaper
Biggest risk	Very crowded genre; the dice hook has to stand out in screenshots	No direct roguelite comparison; 4X fans may not want short sessions
Prototype first	The Loot Roll and dice boons: is rolling fun 50 times?	Does bolting parts onto the truck feel powerful?

PROPOSED **Suggested next step:** build a gray-box prototype of each concept's core moment (one raid plus part pick, or one floor plus a Loot Roll) and playtest both before choosing. No meta systems or store yet.

Both concepts are deliberately scoped for a small team: one hub, one run mode, one meta layer, and a store of about 4 items.

5. SOURCES

Where the Numbers Come From

1. AppMagic Mobile Games Monetization Report 2025 (summary): roguelike +26.2% YoY, RPG $11bn −17%
   https://gamedevreports.substack.com/p/appmagic-mobile-games-monetization
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3. PocketGamer.biz: Archero 2 makes $32.8M in its first 30 days
   https://www.pocketgamer.biz/archero-2-makes-328m-in-first-30-days-from-player-spending
4. PocketGamer.biz: Archero 2 makes $6.6M in its first week
   https://www.pocketgamer.biz/habbys-archero-2-makes-6-6m-in-first-week-over-10-of-archeros-lifetime-earnings
5. Adapty paywall library: Soul Knight revenue and IAP price estimates
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18. TechNode: Whiteout Survival hits $500M in one year
    https://technode.com/2024/03/14/whiteout-survival-achieves-500-million-revenue-within-one-year-of-release/
19. Sensor Tower blog: regional top apocalypse games (example)
    https://sensortower.com/blog/2024-q2-android-top-5-apocalipse%20games-units-ua-601320cf241bc16eb8127cb8
20. Sensor Tower blog: US iOS top space games Q2 2025
    https://sensortower.com/blog/2025-q2-ios-top-5-space%20games-revenue-us-600e9341241bc16eb8f27ad6
21. Sensor Tower: Gaming Deep Dive ad monetization report (ads-first vs IAP-first split)
    https://sensortower.com/blog/gaming-deep-dive-ad-monetization-report

Method and caveats: I gathered these through web search in October 2026. Several pages (Sensor Tower, AppMagic summaries) couldn't be opened directly from my environment, so some figures come from the search engine's excerpts of those pages. All revenue figures are third-party *estimates*, not developer disclosures, and AppMagic (net) and Sensor Tower (gross) measure differently. I found no data for space-themed roguelites, so that genre isn't covered.

Nothing in this brief claims hidden metrics, balance values or developer-confirmed revenue.